

AN EXTRAORDINARY CAREER

- 1 After 38 years, Uday Kotak stepped down in September 2023 as the MD & CEO of the bank he founded. He helped in a smooth succession, with Ashok Vaswani taking over
- 2 He put together a new team that includes top-notch professionals from outside the bank to guide the lender's transformation into a tech-savvy institution
- 3 The bank now boasts a market cap of ₹3.43 lakh crore (as of March 1, 2024). In FY23, the bank reported revenues of ₹34,250 crore and profit of ₹10,939 crore
- 4 The group has evolved into a universal bank covering various sectors, including asset management, alternate asset management, life and general insurance, stockbroking, investment banking, private banking, microfinance, and asset reconstruction
- 5 He has nurtured numerous professionals to assume top positions in various non-banking businesses
- 6 In October 2018, the government requested Uday Kotak to head the crisis-ridden IL&FS board. Kotak and his team successfully recovered ₹55,000 crore, achieving a recovery rate of 56%

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recently stepped down, Kotak had many years to go when he hung up his boots. In fact, he was the youngest in the legendary 3K of Hemendra Kothari of DSP Investment and Nimesh Kampani of JM Financial who ruled Mumbai's investment banking scene for decades, the way 'MGM' or Morgan Stanley, Goldman Sachs, and Merrill Lynch ruled Wall Street.

For Kotak's story, let's start at the very beginning. Growing up in a joint family of 63 members who had been in cotton trading for two generations, Kotak picked up a Bachelor's degree in commerce from Mumbai's Sydenham College and could have joined the family business. But he went for a Master of Management Studies from the Jamnalal Bajaj Institute and then stepped over the bales of cotton into the world of financial services. Specifically, bill discounting.

Kotak also secured the support of Anand Mahindra, four years his senior and a second-generation entrepreneur, who today heads the Mahindra conglomerate. Kotak visited Mahindra at his office in Mahindra Upline and offered a bill-discounting facility. That was the first time Mahindra was meeting Kotak. "He was only in his early twenties, but I saw the signs of a very special mind. I vividly recall telling him that if he ever needed outside capital to come back to me, and to my great good fortune, he did!" wrote Mahindra on X when Kotak retired last year.

Mahindra invested ₹1 lakh in Kotak Mahindra Finance in 1985. Kotak recalls, "We didn't start as high-flying...We began in a bootstrap manner, raising a little bit of capital—a total of ₹30 lakh. The whole concept of entrepreneurship was at the core of who we are, and we combined that with the need for professionalism."

Kotak says he is a product of